

Classic Houmous

Smooth, lemony, garlicky — the way it should be. The trick is whipping the tahini and lemon juice first.

SERVES 4 • ABOUT 10 MINUTES

Ingredients

1	tin of chickpeas (400g)
3 tbsp	tahini
1	lemon, juiced
1	garlic clove, peeled
2 tbsp	extra virgin olive oil
½ tsp	ground cumin
½ tsp	fine salt
3 tbsp	ice-cold water (to loosen, as needed)

Method

1. Drain the chickpeas

Drain the chickpeas but reserve a few tablespoons of the liquid (aquafaba) — useful if you'd rather loosen with that than water for extra body. For a noticeably smoother result, slip the chickpeas out of their skins by pinching them between your fingers; takes a few minutes but worth it.

2. Whip the tahini base

In a food processor, blitz the tahini with the lemon juice for about a minute until thick, pale, and creamy — it'll seize up and look almost like buttercream. This is the step that gives houmous its fluffy texture, so don't skip it.

3. Add aromatics

Add the garlic, cumin, and salt. Blitz again for 30 seconds to break the garlic down completely.

4. Add the chickpeas

Tip in the drained chickpeas and olive oil. Blitz for 2–3 minutes, scraping down the sides once or twice. It'll look thick and gritty at first — keep going.

5. Loosen and adjust

With the motor running, drizzle in the ice-cold water a tablespoon at a time until the houmous turns smooth and silky and falls slowly from a spoon. Taste — it almost always wants more lemon, salt, or both. Serve in a shallow bowl with a swirl of olive oil on top.

Notes & tweaks

A few tweaks worth knowing: a pinch of bicarbonate of soda simmered with the chickpeas for 10 minutes before draining will break down the skins and give you restaurant-smooth houmous without the peeling faff. For a lighter, fluffier texture, blanch the garlic in the lemon juice for a minute first — takes the raw edge off. Toppings to play with: toasted pine nuts, sumac, Aleppo pepper, za'atar, or a spoon of harissa swirled through.